**Focus Group Guide**

**Introduction:**

Welcome:

Good afternoon and welcome! Thanks for taking the time to join us to talk about climate change distress in young adults (18-24). Add intro for focus group leaders.

Overview of Topic:

We are interested in your perspectives on psychological distress due to awareness of climate change. We are conducting a series of focus groups with different experts from the United States and Canada including (modify based on focus group yourselves, environmental epidemiologists, service providers, clinicians, and local and state health public health professionals). Our focus group questions are grouped into three categories: 1) define the construct of climate change distress 2) understand items to include in a short survey measure for large epidemiological surveys (2-4 questions) 3) agenda setting for future work on this topic. Our focus is on climate change distress in young adults 18-24 and the next step in this study will involve measure testing in this population. However, we hope our research can be applied more broadly to additional age groups. This focus group is anticipated to last one hour *[though I will remain available for half an hour longer for any who wish to continue the discussion]*.

Ground Rules:

We do have a few ground rules. We hope everyone will participate and chime-in during the discussion. Please listen respectfully and speak one at a time. There are no wrong answers. We are not trying to achieve consensus but rather gather information. This discussion will be kept confidential so please do not share the specifics of what was said or who participated. Please put away all distractions. Remember, your participation is voluntary, and you can decide not to answer any question or leave the room at any point without repercussion.

The topics we discuss today may be heavy at times and involve a wide range of emotions. Please make sure to take care of yourself and take breaks if needed. (two sentences added for public health focus groups)

Content:

We would like to audio record our discussion today to ensure we accurately capture your responses to our questions. Only myself and other members of the study team will have access to the recording, and all data will be deleted once analysis is complete. The end

result of our study will be a written report describing our findings which we will be very excited to share with everyone here. We will not include your name or organization without your explicit written consent.

- We will go around the room and please answer if you consent to participating in this focus group and being recorded.
- Does anyone have any questions before we begin?
- Turn on recorder on phone and computer.
- One more time, do you consent to participate in this focus group and for this discussion to be recorded? [Ask everyone to provide a verbal "yes"]

First question:
Thank you so much for agreeing to be part of this focus group. To get us started, let's find out more about each other with introductions with your name, pronouns and your professional title or affiliation.

**Study Questions: (15 mins for each section)**
**Defining the construct**

1. Could you provide a definition, in your own words, of "climate distress"?
   a. *Probe*: You may have heard of related terms, including eco anxiety, climate grief, or solastalgia. How do you understand "climate distress" to relate to these or other similar constructs, if at all?

2. (If time) *Here are two working definitions:*

   ***Climate distress*** *is psychological distress about climate change that is NOT due to stress or trauma from experiencing climate change-related adverse weather. It results in functional limitations (e.g., trouble focusing on work or school, disruptions to sleep or eating).*

   ***Climate distress*** *is experienced when individuals perceive the human response to climate change as inconsistent with their personal values, social identity, or sense of self-efficacy and can prevent individuals from flourishing, living a fulfilling life, and reaching their potential.*

   What do you think (or what are your reactions) about these definitions?
   a. *Probe*: How accurately do you feel they reflect climate distress?
   b. *Probe*: What do think is missing from these definitions?

c. *Probe*: What would you change or add to these definitions?

3. (For epidemiologists, public health, on the ground experts) What do you think is different about climate change-related distress, as opposed to other types of distress?
   (For clinicians) As a clinician, how would you distinguish climate distress from other clinical diagnoses, such as anxiety, depression, or adjustment disorder?
   a. *Probe:* Have you observed unique symptoms of climate distress? If so, please describe them.
   b. *Probe:* In your experience, how has the treatment of climate distress differed from the treatment of other psychological problems?
   c. *Follow up, if not mentioned:* We are particularly interested in young people, and young adults especially (ages 18-25). What, if any, experiences of climate distress seem to you to be specific to this population?

   (Additional question for on the ground experts) How have you seen climate distress manifest among populations with whom you have worked? We are interested primarily in feelings, beliefs, or behaviors specific to climate change, and not to mental health in general.
   a. *Follow up, if not mentioned:* We are particularly interested in young people, and young adults especially (ages 18-25). What, if any, experiences of climate distress seem to you to be specific to this population?

**Generating items**

4. In reviewing existing measures, we found that items covered the following themes (see handout). Which of these themes do you find best captures the construct of "climate distress"?
   a. *Probe:* What do you think is missing from these themes?

5. What question or questions would you ask to ascertain whether an individual is experiencing climate distress? If you have 2 questions/5 minutes to talk to somebody to find out if they are experiencing climate distress (per our previous discussion) and NOT something else, what would you ask? (second question added for clinicians and on the ground experts)

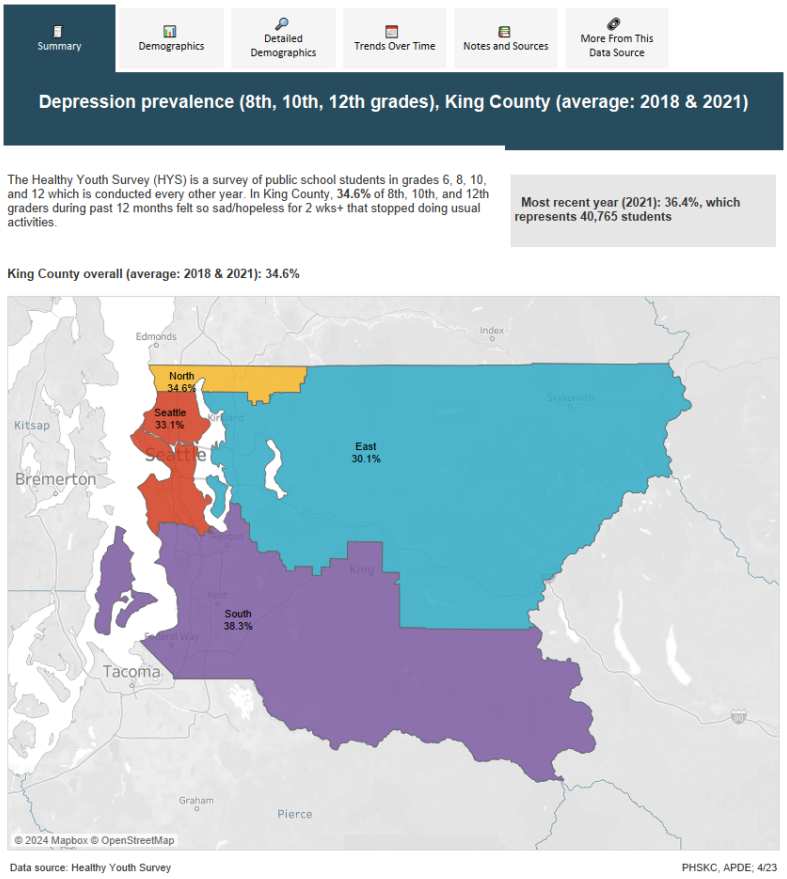
   (Additional question for clinicians) The objective of the current study is to develop a way to better measure climate distress. We recognize survey burden can be a

concern for both clinicians and patients. What do you think would be an appropriate length for an instrument to capture climate distress in your clinical practice?

**Agenda setting**

6. (For epidemiologists, public health, on the ground experts) The objective of the current study is to develop a way to better measure climate distress. What would you use the eventual measure for?
   a. *Probe*: We are particularly interested in young people, and young adults especially (ages 18-25). What would be some applications of climate distress data specifically for this age group?
   b. *Probe*: In what ways do you, in your professional capacity, already use climate change-related or mental health-related data? How would data on climate distress fit in or expand this work?

   (For clinicians) The measure we are developing may be used in population surveys that may produce statistics like the image shown. In what formats do you access these population statistics? And once you learn of them, how do they shape your clinical work?




7. What, in your opinion, are the top priorities in your field for future work on climate distress?

8. (If time) What considerations specific to your geographic context or region do you believe are important to take into account?

**Closing:**

Does anyone have anything else to add? (Wait 10 secs)

Thank you so much for participating in this focus group on climate change distress. We really appreciate you sharing your expertise and look forward to writing up our results this fall and into 2025. You will be receiving a prepaid Visa gift card to your email in the next month (take out for local health). We will be sticking around if anyone has additional thoughts or comments. Enjoy the rest of your day!